

More waste separated, but how much recycled?

Testing a public claim about waste in Malta against Eurostat, NSO and EU targets

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

“Malta continues to make strong progress in waste management.”

Ministry for the Environment, Energy and Public Cleanliness, press release PR260072en, 19 January 2026.

Minister Dalli: “our Long-Term Waste Management Plan is working”; 412 million kg diverted.

VERDICT: NOT SUBSTANTIATED

Separation is up, but 16.7% was recycled in 2024 and 79% landfilled

TL;DR

On 19 January 2026 the Ministry for the Environment said Malta was making “**strong progress**” in **waste separation**: mixed waste down by over 30% to 95.5 million kg, a record 30 million kg of organic waste, and about **412 million kg diverted from landfill over five years**. The Minister said the Long-Term Waste Management Plan “is working”. We tested these statements against the measure EU law uses, the share of municipal waste that is actually recycled, and against the European Commission’s own assessments of Malta.

- 1

Separation and recycling are both rising. The recycling rate rose from 9.1% (2019) to 16.7% (2024), the 4th-largest rise of the 20 EU states with data for both years. Packaging recycling rose from 30.8% to 43.4% in 2023, the deposit scheme’s first full year.
- 2

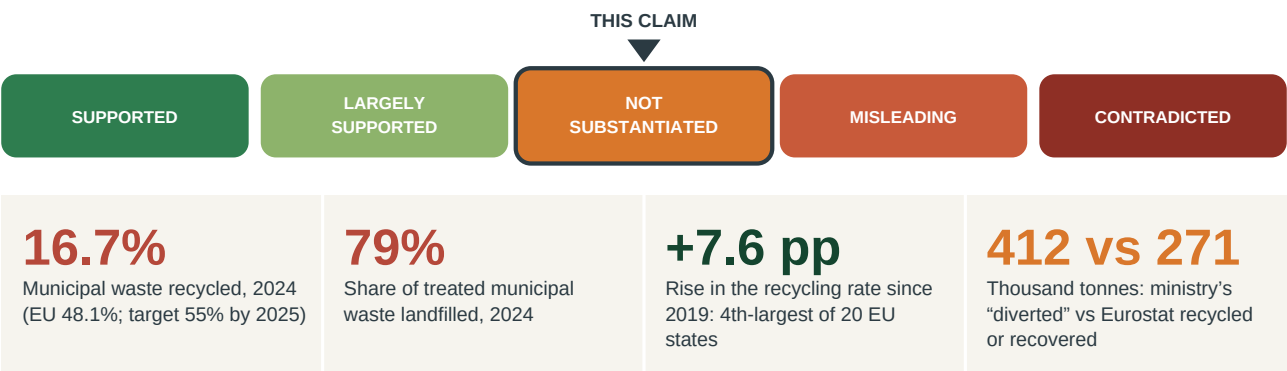
But the level is far from the target. 16.7% is the second-lowest of the 20 states with 2024 data (EU average 48%). The target is 55% by 2025, and Malta renounced a postponement in November 2024.
- 3

Four-fifths still goes to landfill. 79% of treated municipal waste in 2024. In 2023 the Commission listed Malta among 10 states at risk of missing both 2025 targets.
- 4

Collected organic waste does not count as recycled. Treated biowaste is used for landscaping and landfill remediation, so it is reported as landfilled. Counting all 30 million kg would lift the rate to about 25%.
- 5

The 412 million kg cannot be reconciled with published data. Eurostat records 271 thousand tonnes recycled or energy-recovered in 2020–2024; the release gives no scope, years or method.
- 6

Verdict: not substantiated. Progress is real and faster than in most EU states, but “the plan is working” and the diversion figure are stated more strongly than the published evidence allows.



WHAT WOULD MOVE THE VERDICT UP The scope, years and method behind 412 million kg, reconciled with NSO and Eurostat; sorting-plant reject rates showing most separated waste is recycled; compost and digestate put to uses that count as recycling; an official projection showing Malta will reach 55% by a stated date.	WHAT WOULD MOVE IT DOWN Evidence that “diverted” counts collected weight including rejects later landfilled, or includes construction waste; a 2025 recycling rate no higher than 2024.
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1

The claim and what we could verify

The claim is the Department of Information press release PR260072en of 19 January 2026, read in full [1]. It reports a press conference by Minister Miriam Dalli and WasteServ CEO Richard Bilocca. A copy on publicservice.gov.mt (23 January) could not be opened [2]. Our candidate file also cited ERA’s “68% recycled” figure; reading ERA’s statement in full [9] shows it is explicitly about construction and demolition waste, so it is not part of this claim and our earlier note has been corrected.

Source	What it says	Our access	Status
Ministry press release, 19 Jan 2026 [1]	Mixed waste down over 30%, now 95.5 million kg, “down from approximately 141 million kg”. Organic waste a record 30 million kg in 2025. Commercial mixed waste –1.1% (2024–25). Minister: “our Long-Term Waste Management Plan is working”; “we have diverted roughly 412 million kilogrammes of waste away from landfill over the past five years”.	Read in full in a browser (site blocks automated access).	The claim
NSO, Municipal Waste 2024 [4]; Solid Waste Management 2024 [5]	353,525 t municipal waste generated; 79.2% of treated municipal waste landfilled; 58,156 t recycled. Household separate collections up.	Salient points read.	Primary data
Eurostat [3]	Recycling rates for all EU-27 states, treatment routes and packaging rates.	Downloaded 2 and 5 Oct 2026.	Primary data
European Commission, early-warning report, June 2023 [8], with its Malta annex [12]	Malta at risk of missing both 2025 targets (municipal and packaging) and far from the 2035 landfill target; compost used for landscaping and landfill remediation.	Read in full (EU Publications Office), 5 Oct 2026.	EU assessment
European Commission, Environmental Implementation Review 2025, Malta [6]	Missed the 2020 target by a large margin; on course to miss 2025. Postponement notified (Dec 2023), packaging part not accepted, then renounced (Nov 2024). Treated biowaste reported as landfilled.	Waste chapter (pp. 3–11) read in full, 5 Oct 2026.	EU assessment

FAIRNESS NOTE

Malta has introduced the kinds of measure the research associates with higher recycling: mandatory separation and regional collection (2023), a deposit refund scheme (November 2022), new sorting plants (2023–24) and gate fees for mixed waste rising from €40 to €120 a tonne between 2023 and 2027 [6]. Weekly food-waste collection and less frequent residual collection were linked to higher recycling rates across 297 districts in England and Wales [10]. Malta’s rate has risen faster than in most EU states. This check is about whether the release’s conclusions follow from its figures.

2

Method

Question. Do the figures in the release show “strong progress” and a plan that “is working”, when tested against the recycling and landfill measures that Malta’s EU obligations use?

Evidence. Eurostat municipal-waste tables (*cei_wm011*, *env_wasmun*, *cei_wm020*) and NSO releases, downloaded or read on 2 October 2026, and *cei_wm011* for all EU-27 states, downloaded on 5 October 2026; the Waste Framework Directive as amended in 2018 [7]; the Commission’s 2023 early-warning report and its Malta annex [8, 12] and its 2025 Environmental Implementation Review for Malta [6], read in full from the EU Publications Office on 5 October 2026. All percentages are recomputed by script (*tools/cc-004-report/calc.py*; outputs in *data/cc-004/*). A Crossref search found no peer-reviewed study of Malta’s municipal waste system; one observational study on collection policy is used for context [10].

Grades. Official statistics and EU assessments: C. The collection-policy study: B. **Verdicts** follow Appendix A.

3 Separated, recycled, diverted

The release uses three different measures, and they are easy to run together.

- 1. Separated (collected) weight.** Kilograms placed in organic, grey or green bags, glass banks or the deposit scheme. This is an *input*: it includes contamination and items that sorting plants later reject.
- 2. Recycled weight.** Under Article 11a of the Waste Framework Directive, recycled municipal waste is the weight that, “having undergone all necessary checking, sorting and other preliminary operations”, enters the recycling operation [7]. This is the *outcome* the 55% target is measured on.
- 3. Diverted from landfill.** Not defined in the release. It could mean weight collected separately, weight recycled, or weight sent anywhere but landfill (including energy recovery and exports).

WHY IT MATTERS HERE

A rise in separated weight is a necessary step towards recycling, but the recycling rate is what EU law and the Commission assess. The release reports measure 1, and an undefined measure 3. It does not report measure 2. Our methodology calls this pattern *input-as-outcome*, and using a favourable measure where the regulator uses a different one a *selective metric*.

4 What the data show

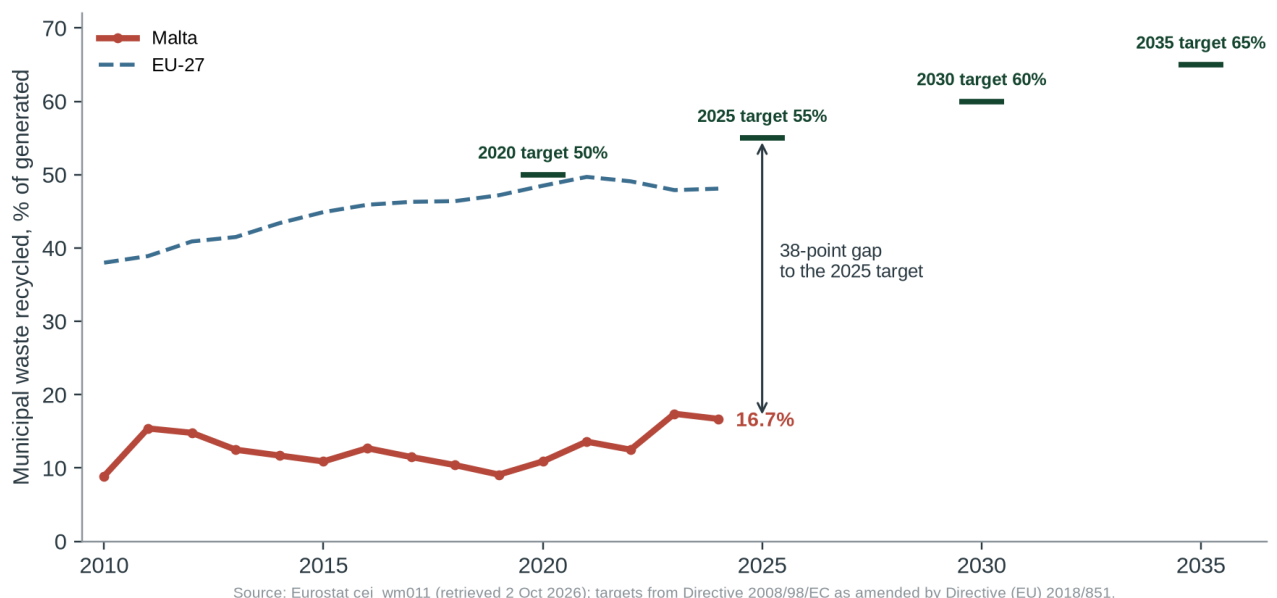
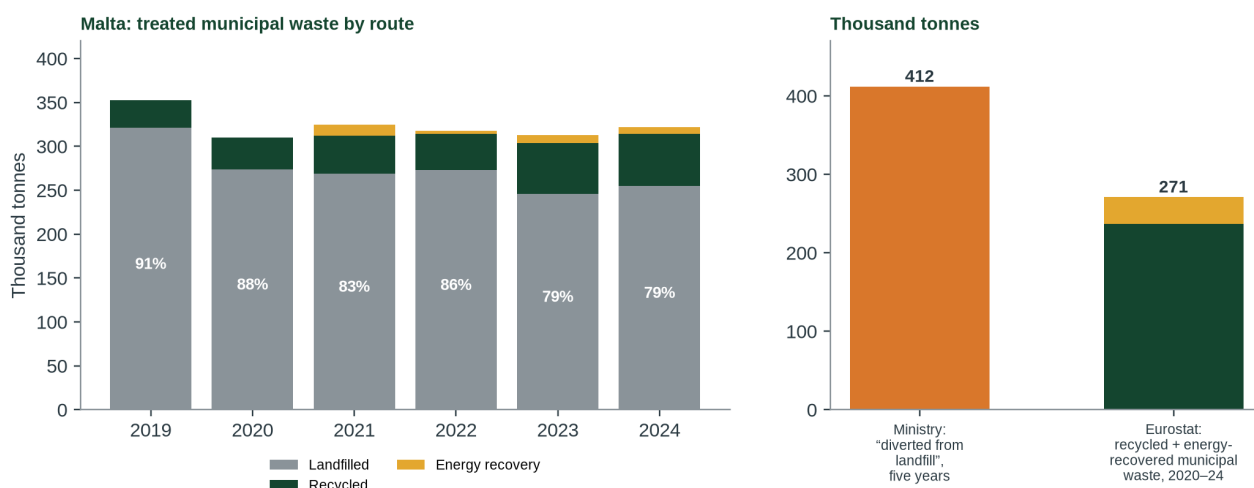


Figure 1. Share of municipal waste recycled, Malta and EU-27, with the EU targets. Malta's rate has risen from 9.1% (2019) to 16.7% (2024), roughly 1.5 points a year.



Source: Eurostat env_wasmun (retrieved 2 Oct 2026); Ministry press release PR260072en, 19 Jan 2026. The ministry's five-year window and scope are not stated.

Figure 2. Left: what happened to Malta's treated municipal waste, with the landfilled share. Right: the ministry's five-year "diverted" figure beside Eurostat's recycled and energy-recovered municipal waste for 2020–2024. The windows may differ by a year: 2025 data are not yet published.

Indicator	Malta	EU-27 / target	Source	Grade
Municipal recycling rate, 2024	16.7%	48.1% / 55% by 2025	Eurostat cei_wm011 [3]	C
Municipal recycling rate, 2019	9.1%	47.2%	Eurostat [3]	C
Change in recycling rate, 2019 to 2024	+7.6 points	4th-largest rise of 20 states	Eurostat [3]	C
Landfilled share of treated municipal waste, 2024	79%	–	Eurostat env_wasmun; NSO [3, 4]	C
Landfilled municipal waste, 2019 to 2024	321 to 255 kt (–21%)	–	Eurostat [3]	C
Municipal waste generated, 2019 to 2024	351 to 354 kt (+1%)	–	Eurostat [3]	C
Recycled + energy-recovered, 2020–2024	271 kt	Ministry: 412 million kg "diverted"	Eurostat [3]; [1]	C
Composting and digestion counted as recycling, 2019–2024	0 t each year	–	Eurostat env_wasmun (RCY_C_D) [3]	C
Packaging recycling rate, 2022 to 2023	30.8% to 43.4%	67.4% (2023) / 65% by 2025	Eurostat cei_wm020 [3]	C
Plastic packaging recycling rate, 2022 to 2023	13.8% to 31.9%	41.7% (2023) / 50% by 2025	Eurostat cei_wm020 [3]	C
Deposit refund scheme, 2023: containers collected / recycled	78% / 74%	–	Commission [6, p. 11], citing ERA	C
2020 municipal target	Missed by a large margin	50%	Commission [6, p. 3]	C

Values in data/cc-004/checks.csv. kt = thousand tonnes = million kg. Deposit-scheme rates are shares of containers placed on the market, as reported; we did not recompute them.

Malta among the EU-27

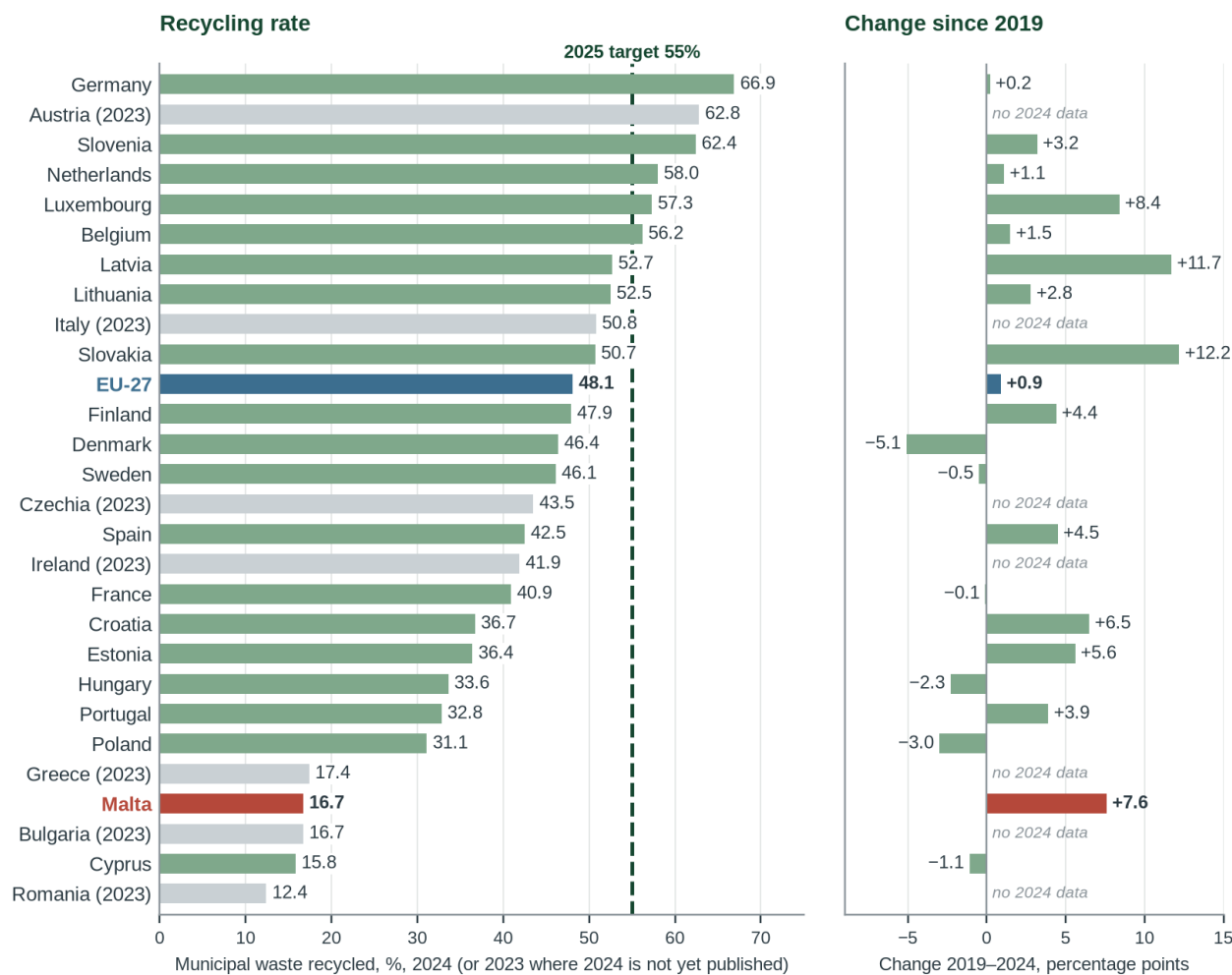


Figure 3. Municipal recycling rates of the EU-27 states, latest year, and the change since 2019. Seven states have not yet published 2024. Malta's rise is the 4th-largest of the 20 with both years, after Slovakia, Latvia and Luxembourg; its level is the second-lowest of those 20, above Cyprus.

Reading across the data

- **The direction is right, and the pace is above the EU norm.** The recycling rate nearly doubled from 2019, the landfilled tonnage fell by a fifth while generation stayed flat, and only three states with comparable data raised their rate faster (Figure 3).
- **The level is far from the target.** At the 2019–2024 pace of about 1.5 points a year, reaching 55% would take roughly 25 years (an illustrative straight-line extrapolation, not a forecast). Malta notified the Commission in December 2023 that it intended to postpone the 2025 targets; the Commission did not accept the packaging part, and in November 2024 Malta renounced the postponement [6, p. 8]. As we read it, the 2025 deadline therefore applies in full.
- **Packaging recycling jumped in 2023.** All packaging rose from 30.8% to 43.4%, plastic from 13.8% to 31.9% and glass from 43.3% to 65.2% [3]. The deposit refund scheme began in November 2022; the Commission reports that in 2023 it collected 78% of the beverage containers placed on the market and recycled 74% [6, p. 11]. That the scheme drove the jump is our inference: the timing fits, but the data cannot separate it from other changes. Packaging is still 21.6 points below its 2025 target of 65%.
- **Separately collected organic waste does not show up as recycling, and the Commission says why.** Eurostat records zero tonnes of Maltese municipal waste recycled by composting or digestion in each year from 2019 to 2024. Treated biowaste “is used for landscaping and landfill remediation” and is “consequently reported as

landfilled” [6, p. 9]. The 2023 annex also noted the landscaping and landfill use, and recommended using compost and digestate for land improvement and as fertiliser [12, pp. 2–3]. Even if all 30 million kg of organic waste the release reports for 2025 were counted as recycled, the rate would be about 25% (indicative: 2025 tonnage against 2024 totals).

- **Measurement is hard where waste is exported.** The Commission notes that Malta finds it “particularly challenging” to measure how much waste actually enters recycling because it relies on exports, and that sorted packaging is stored until there is enough to ship, so annual rates fluctuate [6, pp. 9–10].
- **The 412 million kg is about 140 thousand tonnes more** than Eurostat’s recycled and energy-recovered municipal waste for 2020–2024. If the ministry’s five years are 2021–2025, the 2025 figure would have to exceed 170 thousand tonnes to close the gap, more than two and a half times the 2024 level. The figure may include commercial or non-municipal streams; the release does not say.

5 Where the evidence points different ways

Q1 Is separation the right thing to measure?

USEFUL, NOT SUFFICIENT

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

Separation at source is a precondition for high-quality recycling, and the measures Malta introduced (mandatory separation, gate fees, weekly organics) match those associated with higher recycling elsewhere [10]. Household separate collections rose in 2024 [5].

EVIDENCE AGAINST

EU targets are set on recycled weight after sorting [7]. Malta’s recycling rate is about a third of the EU average and 38 points below the 2025 target [3]. Separated weight can rise while rejects are landfilled.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: the figures support “progress in separation”. They do not by themselves support “the plan is working” if the plan is judged by recycling outcomes.

Q2 Is the trend fast enough to call it strong progress?

ON CURRENT DATA, NO

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

The recycling rate rose from 9.1% to 16.7% in five years, the 4th-largest rise of 20 EU states (Figure 3). Packaging recycling rose 12.6 points in 2023. Separation measures began in 2023 and may take time to show. Mixed waste fell by over 30% on the ministry’s figures [1].

EVIDENCE AGAINST

In 2023 the Commission listed Malta among 10 states “at risk of missing both the targets for municipal and all packaging waste for 2025” [8, p. 3] and 13 “still far from” the 2035 landfill target [8, p. 10]. Its 2025 review says the 2020 target was missed “by a large margin” [6, p. 3]. The rate dipped from 17.4% (2023) to 16.7% (2024) [3].

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

“Strong” is a judgement. Relative to Malta’s past, and to most EU states’ pace, it is defensible; relative to the legal target, which now applies without postponement, it is not. **For this claim:** the release gives only the first comparison.

Q3 Do the release’s own numbers add up?

CANNOT BE CHECKED

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

The 141 to 95.5 million kg change is –32%, consistent with “over 30%”. Landfilled municipal waste fell 21% in 2019–2024 [3], the same direction.

EVIDENCE AGAINST

No start year is given for 141 million kg, and “mixed waste” is not a published NSO or Eurostat series. The 412 million kg exceeds Eurostat’s recycled and recovered tonnage by about 140 thousand tonnes.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: the figures may come from WasteServ operational data. Until scope and method are published, they cannot be reproduced.

Q4 Does 16.7% understate what Malta recycles?

PARTLY; IT IS STILL THE TEST

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

Organic waste is collected and treated but, because the output is used for landscaping and landfill remediation, it is reported as landfilled [6, p. 9]. Exports make the tonnage entering recycling hard to measure, and stored packaging makes annual rates swing [6, pp. 9–10].

EVIDENCE AGAINST

EU law counts only waste that enters a recycling operation [7]; the Commission states that the treatment of organic waste in Malta “does not qualify as recycling” [6, p. 11]. Counting all 30 million kg of organic waste would lift the rate to about 25%, still 30 points short of 55%.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: measurement and compost use may hide some effort, but not enough to close the gap. Using compost and digestate on land, as the Commission recommended in 2023 [12, p. 3], is one way the collected organic waste could start to count.

6 Testing the claim

Sub-claim	Said by	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. Mixed waste down over 30%, to 95.5 million kg from about 141 million kg	Ministry [1]	Arithmetic correct (–32%). No start year; not a published statistic. Direction consistent with Eurostat landfill data.	UNVERIFIABLE AS STATED
B. Organic waste a record 30 million kg in 2025	Ministry [1]	2025 data not yet published by NSO. 2024 NSO data show organic-bag collections rising. Treated organic waste is reported as landfilled, not recycled [6].	PLAUSIBLE
C. About 412 million kg diverted from landfill over five years	Minister Dalli [1]	Not reconcilable with Eurostat (271 kt recycled or recovered, 2020–24). Scope, years and method not stated.	NOT SUBSTANTIATED
D. Malta records strong progress in waste separation	Ministry [1]	Separated collections and the recycling rate have risen, faster than in most EU states. “Strong” is relative to Malta’s past, not to its targets.	PARTLY SUPPORTED
E. The Long-Term Waste Management Plan is working; real and measurable outcomes	Minister Dalli [1]	Outcome measures: 16.7% recycled, 79% landfilled; 2020 target missed, 2025 on course to be missed, now without postponement [3, 6, 8]. The release does not report them.	NOT SUBSTANTIATED

A CORRECTION TO OUR OWN CANDIDATE NOTE

Our candidate list said ERA’s ‘68% recycled’ figure “covers mostly inert construction material”, implying it might be read as a general recycling rate. ERA’s statement says plainly that 68% of construction waste was recycled [9]. ERA did not present it as municipal recycling, and we have removed that point from this check.

7 Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

NOT SUBSTANTIATED

Separation is up, but only 16.7% of municipal waste was recycled in 2024 (target 55% by 2025) and 79% of treated waste was landfilled. Confidence: high.

Why. (1) Separate collection is rising and the recycling rate has improved from a very low base, faster than in most EU states, so “progress in waste separation” is supported. (2) The release presents collected weight and an undefined “diverted” figure as evidence that the plan “is working”, but the outcome measures used by EU law show 16.7% recycled and 79% landfilled, far from the 55% target for 2025, which Malta has chosen not to postpone. The

Commission’s 2023 and 2025 assessments reach the same conclusion. (3) The 412 million kg figure cannot be reconciled with published statistics. We chose *Not substantiated* rather than *Misleading* because the release is framed around separation, where its direction is right, and because the ministry may hold data that explain the 412 figure. Confidence is high because three Commission assessments and Eurostat agree on the outcome; the unexplained 412 figure is a caveat, not a gap in the finding.

What this verdict does not say. It does not say the figures are invented, that separation measures were wrong, or that anyone acted in bad faith. A checkable statement would read: “*Separate collection rose to X t; after sorting, Y t entered recycling, raising the recycling rate to Z%. We expect to reach 55% by [year].*”

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ The years, waste streams (household, commercial, deposit scheme, construction) and measurement point behind “412 million kg diverted from landfill”.
- ☐ The start year and definition of “mixed waste” in the 141 to 95.5 million kg comparison.
- ☐ Reject rates at sorting plants: how much separately collected grey- and green-bag waste is landfilled after sorting.
- ☐ How much compost and digestate the organic waste produced, where it was used, and when its use is expected to count as recycling.
- ☐ Malta’s expected 2025 municipal recycling rate, and the year in which the plan expects to reach 55%.

RIGHT OF REPLY

Before wider circulation this draft should be sent to the Ministry for the Environment, Energy and Public Cleanliness and to WasteServ with a fixed deadline (suggested 14 days). Responses will be appended and the verdict revisited.

8

Limitations

- This is a statistical check. No peer-reviewed study of Malta’s municipal waste system was found; the one study used [10] is from England and Wales and is read as an abstract.
- 2025 statistics are not yet published, so the ministry’s 2025 figures cannot be checked and the five-year windows may not match. Seven EU states have not yet published 2024 recycling rates.
- We read NSO salient points, not the full NSO tables.
- The Commission’s 2025 review uses data to 2022, and its deposit-scheme rates come from ERA; we did not recompute them. The link between the deposit scheme and the 2023 packaging jump is our inference.
- The publicservice.gov.mt version of the release could not be opened; we assume it matches the DOI text.

References

- [1] Ministry for the Environment, Energy and Public Cleanliness (19 Jan 2026). Malta records strong progress in waste separation. Press release PR260072en. (Read in full in a browser on 2 Oct 2026.) <https://www.gov.mt/en/Government/DOI/Press%20Releases/Pages/2026/01/19/PR260072en.aspx>
- [2] Malta records strong progress in waste separation (23 Jan 2026). publicservice.gov.mt. (Not read.) <https://publicservice.gov.mt/en/news/malta-records-strong-progress-in-waste-separation>
- [3] Eurostat. Recycling rate of municipal waste (cei_wm011); Municipal waste by waste management operations (env_wasmun); Recycling rate of packaging waste (cei_wm020). Retrieved 2 Oct 2026; cei_wm011 for all EU-27 states retrieved 5 Oct 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/cei_wm011/default/table
- [4] National Statistics Office (2 Dec 2025). Municipal Waste: 2024. News Release 225/2025. <https://nso.gov.mt/municipal-waste-2024/>
- [5] National Statistics Office (17 Feb 2026). Solid Waste Management: 2024. News Release 023/2026. <https://nso.gov.mt/solid-waste-management-2024/>
- [6] European Commission (7 Jul 2025). 2025 Environmental Implementation Review: Country Report – Malta. SWD(2025) 318 final. Waste chapter, pp. 3–11, read in full (via the EU Publications Office, 5 Oct 2026). Summary page:

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<https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/?uri=CELEX:52025SC0318>

- [7] Directive (EU) 2018/851 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 30 May 2018 amending Directive 2008/98/EC on waste. OJ L 150, 14.6.2018, p. 109. Articles 11(2) and 11a. <https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/?uri=CELEX:32018L0851>
- [8] European Commission (8 Jun 2023). Report identifying Member States at risk of not meeting the 2025 preparing for re-use and recycling target for municipal waste, the 2025 recycling target for packaging waste and the 2035 municipal waste landfilling reduction target (early-warning report). COM(2023) 304 final. Read in full. <https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/?uri=CELEX:52023DC0304>
- [9] Environment and Resources Authority (19 Feb 2025). NSO data reveals positive trends in sustainability and resource recovery. <https://era.org.mt/press-releases/nso-data-reveals-positive-trends-in-sustainability-and-resource-recovery/>
- [10] Wilansky J., Cao K. (2026). A comparison of municipal waste collection policies to optimize recycling rates: evidence from England and Wales. *Waste Management* 210:115258. doi:10.1016/j.wasman.2025.115258. (Abstract read.) <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.wasman.2025.115258>
- [11] MiŻien. Scripts and outputs: tools/cc-004-report/fetch_eurostat.py, calc.py, figures.py; data/cc-004/checks.csv.
- [12] European Commission (8 Jun 2023). The early warning report for Malta. Commission Staff Working Document SWD(2023) 195 final, accompanying COM(2023) 304. Read in full. <https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/?uri=CELEX:52023SC0195>

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate:** evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low:** evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ♦ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline**, with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it**, and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify**, and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** before wider circulation and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	2 Oct 2026	First issue. Draft pending right of reply from the Ministry for the Environment, Energy and Public Cleanliness and WasteServ.
1.1	5 Oct 2026	Upgrade: the Commission's early-warning report [8] and Malta annex [12] read directly (second-hand marker removed); its 2025 review [6] read in full (postponement renounced; biowaste reported as landfilled). New Figure 3 (EU-27); verified fairness points (+7.6 points, 4th of 20; packaging and deposit scheme); new Q4. Maintainer decision (5 Oct 2026): confidence raised from moderate to high, because three Commission documents and Eurostat now agree. Verdict unchanged.